

Ravenloft I6 Playability Guide

Part IV

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Editorial note. This guide works from I6 itself. Where it reaches beyond the module, it says so. The itinerant clan the module calls "gypsies" is named Rhenari throughout, following the convention set out in Part I Section 2. Direct quotations from the module retain the original wording.

1. The road west from the village

Part III ended with the party leaving the village, Ireena with them and Ismark too if the DM sent him along, the Tome of Strahd named at the church, and the cemetery's midnight procession seen or at least inferred. Part IV opens on the road west of the village.

1a. Leaving the village

The road leaves the village heading west, crosses the river by a bridge, and runs on through the woods to the junction at F (Map 1). The trees thicken quickly and the fog comes back. This is the same forest Part II Section 4 was about.

The module prints its wolf procedure for the woods at C (p.8): a d6 every turn [10 minutes] in the woods, a lone wolf crying on a 4 or higher, another each round [1 minute], and an attack after five rounds of howling, five worgs if the party is entering Barovia and twenty-five if it is attempting to leave. Map 1 marks no C woods between the village and F, and I6 does not restate the procedure for this road, so it does not follow the party here automatically. A DM who extends it beyond C is making a deliberate ruling, not running the module's procedure.

1b. F, the junction, and the two forks

The road splits. The module's description on p.11: "Suddenly, the road splits into the forbidding Svalich woods. The northern fork slants up slightly to the north while the southern fork slants slightly downward. Dense fog obscures your vision. A cold autumn wind whistles down the northern lane, cutting icily through your clothing. Dead brown leaves rush about. There is no sound other than the wind and leaves."

The north fork leads to G, the Tser Pool encampment. The south fork leads to I, a second junction with the carriage that goes to the castle. At the fork the players have only what the boxed text gives them: two roads, one climbing and one descending, fog, wind, leaves, and no other sound. Nothing tells them which way the castle lies, and nothing tells them the Rhenari camp is north. A party may take the north fork because it is tracking the

Rhenari who took its property (Part II Section 1e), or simply because it chooses to. The DM knows Madam Eva is up that road. The players do not, and the DM should not steer them toward her. A party that takes the southern fork and never reaches G has missed Madam Eva but not the Fortunes: there is no new reading, and play continues on the prep results (p.11, Part I Section 5c).

2. Tser Pool and the Rhenari

2a. The camp as it presents

The north fork passes close by a clearing on the banks of a dark pool. The module's description is specific: the branches give way to black clouds boiling above, dry grass rustles in a biting wind, colorful wagons sit on the banks, an accordion mixes with the wind, figures surround a large fire. Ten Rhenari are in the camp. The Rhenari are the guide's name for the itinerant clan the module calls "gypsies," introduced in Part I Section 2. They are armed and capable, 4th-level fighters with substantial hit points, but their opening move on the party is to invite them to the fire and to sing.

One of the Rhenari tells the party what the party half-expected: "It was fated that you would visit this humble camp. Madam Eva foretold your coming. She awaits you." This is the camp's essential line before the Fortunes reading. It is also the camp acknowledging that the party's arrival was not unexpected.

The Rhenari attack only if the party shows hostility or gives insult inside the camp. Short of that, the welcome is the welcome.

2b. Recognition: Anshel Rhen again

If the DM used the camouflaged opening from Part II, the Rhenari leader who hired the party at the hamlet tavern, Anshel Rhen, is among the ten. He does not apologise. He does not explain. He is simply present, and that presence is the acknowledgment that the hamlet deception was their work. A party that recognises him has recognised the pattern the rest of the valley has been teaching them: a smiling welcome in Barovia is no evidence of an ally.

In the module's as-written opening, the messenger who delivered the forged letter in the tavern is a gypsy, which the guide renders as Rhenari. The module does not place him at G. A DM may put him among the ten at the fire, and the same logic then applies, but that is the DM's choice rather than the module's text.

No explanation is offered, and the party will not be given one.

2c. The stolen item, and the welcome

In the camouflaged opening, the camp is where the stolen possession from Part II Section 1e reappears. It may be returned in hand as the welcome is offered. It may be lying in one of the wagons, unmistakably present. The Rhenari do not present it as theft. They present it as property returned, as if the theft never happened. A party that presses the point gets nothing. A party that accepts the return has accepted the grammar of the encampment, which is that things happen at Tser Pool and are not discussed at Tser Pool.

In the module's as-written opening, there was no theft, and this subsection is skipped. The welcome is bare: the fire, the song, and the tent behind the fire.

3. The Fortunes reading at Madam Eva's tent

3a. Who Madam Eva is

Madam Eva is a 10th-level cleric, explicitly aligned CN rather than NE, with a spell list that extends to 5th-level raise dead and true seeing. The module's own note on her is plain: she is "cunning and sharp of mind," "never fooled by adventurers," having seen a good many in her time, and "serves Strahd as long as that benefits her and her troupe." The module is also explicit that she "never gives aid and never needs any."

The CN alignment is important. She is not Strahd's partisan. She is a survivor whose arrangement with Strahd is transactional and whose loyalty extends as far as the arrangement does. Part I Section 5f framed her reading as real sight delivered inside a relationship of service to the vampire. The sight is hers. The service is the seer's contract.

3b. How the Fortunes are being run

The module's procedure at G1 applies only if the PCs enter the tent (p.11). A party that passes the camp, or will not go in, hears no reading, and the prep results stand. Inside, Madam Eva speaks the name of each PC, refers to a past deed of each, and asks whether they want their fortunes read. If they agree, the reading follows the Fortunes sequence on p.4. If they decline, the results the DM generated before play stand.

The party's answer at the tent decides which results the rest of the adventure runs on. If they accept, the reading is run again, out loud, with the party watching, and the new results replace the ones the DM drew before play (p.4). Strahd may be somewhere else now, the objects may have moved, and his goal may have changed. If they decline, the prep results stand unspoken. The private redraw from Part I Section 5c remains available as a deliberate departure from the module's "out loud", if the DM has chosen it in advance.

The best case is a DM who has prepared for an accepted reading: a blank location sheet and Strahd sheet to hand, and five minutes at the next break to re-mark the master map. The worse case is a reading accepted cold, with the DM trying to reconfigure the castle at the table while the party waits.

3c. What Madam Eva controls is delivery, not the cards

Once drawn, the cards are fixed. Madam Eva's control lies in emphasis, tone, and what she chooses to make sound urgent.

Her voice on the Places (Table 1) entries shapes how the party hears them. The Ace result for Strahd's starting position puts him in his own coffin, which reads as "the very heart of darkness: his home, his source." In Madam Eva's mouth this can sound like the path the party is fated to walk, or like an ordinary warning of danger. In the first register, a party inclined to heroism will march toward Strahd's coffin. In the second, they will learn where to avoid.

The Goals (Table 3) entry is the single reading the party gets of what Strahd is actually trying to do. Madam Eva's voice on the goal omen colours how urgently the party interprets it. The sphere-of-darkness reading can sound like an old collector's errand or a pressing threat; the module's own account is that the completed sphere would extend the range of his travels. The Ireena reading (Table 3, Jack or Queen: win her love) can sound as if her fate is weeks away or hours away. She chooses.

The DM's work during the reading is Madam Eva's editorial voice. She serves Strahd as long as that benefits her and her troupe, so her emphasis can lean toward what suits him without the reading ever becoming false. The sight is accurate. The weighting is hers.

4. The southern fork, the carriage, and the crossing

4a. Back to F, and south

Whatever happened at Tser Pool, the castle lies beyond I. A party at G can go back to F and take the southern fork, or follow the trail that runs on past the camp along the river and joins the road at the bridge by H (Map 1). Ireena is with them (Part III Section 2d). Ismark is with them only if the DM sent him along (Part III Section 3a).

The southern fork descends. The module's cue at F was that the southern fork "slants slightly downward" while the northern fork climbs. On Map 1 it is the long way round: it winds west and then north, crosses the river by the bridge, and climbs to I.

4b. I, the carriage, and the point of no return

At I the road splits again. A dirt road continues northwest. An older road, showing patches of cobblestone, runs east into dense forest. To the right side of the fork stands a carriage drawn by two black horses. The carriage door swings open. As at F, nothing at I tells the players where either road goes. The carriage is the only signpost, and it is Strahd's.

The horses are under Strahd's control. If the party gets in, the carriage takes them to area J, the castle gates, and the horses cannot be discouraged from their course. A party that wants to walk the east road can walk it instead. The horses wait until the PCs get in (p.11), so a party that walks leaves the carriage standing at I. The other option at I is the dirt road northwest. It runs a short way to Barovia's second gate, west of the crossroads (p.6, Map 1). Map 1 marks it B, like the gate the party came in by, so it shares that gate's description (p.2), and it will not open for the party. Like the east gate, it bars the road rather than the landscape (Part II Section 3b). A party that inspects it and turns back has not tried to leave. A party that tries to go round it through the woods is attempting to leave Barovia, and the procedure at C applies, with twenty-five worgs (p.8). The module ends that attack only when a party enters the village, and there is no village on this side, so where it stops is the DM's ruling.

A party that refuses the carriage and walks east toward J is also travelling through C, but is neither entering nor attempting to leave Barovia. I6 gives no worg figure for that case, so whether the procedure produces an attack, and in what strength, is the DM's ruling.

The carriage is Strahd's offer of accommodation to guests he is expecting. Convenient and direct, and it goes only one way. A party that gets in has committed.

4c. Tser Falls in the distance, and what H tells the party

H is the bottom of Tser Falls. The module describes it as having nothing of interest. What H provides is a sightline: a stone bridge visible nearly a thousand feet overhead. On Map 1 that bridge carries the road from F, and the trail from G, across the river on the way to I. The party crosses it on foot before it ever sees the carriage. From the bridge the drop to H is the measure of the land they are climbing into, with the castle still to come.

H is keyed, but the module gives it no content. Its value is context the DM can fold into the approach, especially if the carriage is carrying them up the road with Ravenloft rising ahead.

4d. Ireena on the castle road

Ireena travels with the party (p.9; Part III Section 2d). A party that tries to leave her at Tser Pool finds Madam Eva will not take her, because she never gives aid (p.11). The castle approach is therefore hers as well as theirs.

Under the Ireena goal (Table 3, Jack or Queen: win her love), the castle is where Strahd can stage the rescue he hopes will turn her heart. Under the other three goals she is leverage rather than the central target. The best case is a party that treats her as the target she is under every goal, and keeps her inside its formation through the castle. The worse case is a party that mistakes her immunity from the wolves (Part III Section 3c) for safety, and loses track of her once the castle starts separating them.

5. Where Part IV should stop

The clean stopping point is the party committed to the road from I to J. Usually that means the carriage door closing behind them, the horses drawing it east toward J, and the castle rising ahead through the fog. A party that refuses the carriage and walks the east road reaches the same place on foot (Map 1).

That is a complete Part IV. The party has crossed the last mundane geography of the valley, heard the Fortunes read again at the tent or played on with the prep results, brought Ireena with them, and committed to the castle approach by carriage or on foot. Everything else belongs to Castle Ravenloft.

Part V takes the party into the castle from here, through J (the gates) and into the keyed K-rooms. J's boxed text assumes the carriage (p.11), and Part V notes how to adapt it for a party arriving on foot. It is where the apparatus of Part I Section 4e opens for play, and where the Fortunes reading's placements start to matter.

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